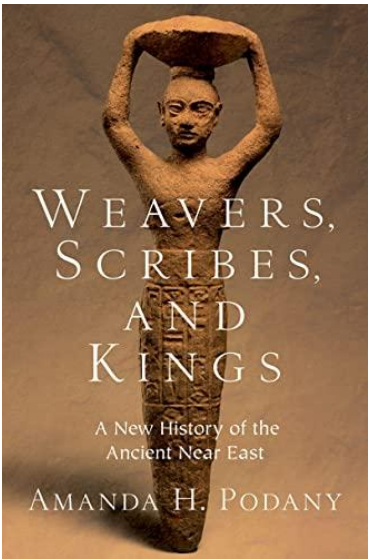




kindle

Weavers, Scribes, and Kings

by Podany, Amanda H.

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Annotations (80)

- 49 Highlights | Yellow (49)
- 2 Bookmarks | Blue (2)
- 29 Notes

Introduction

Page 4 | Highlight (Yellow)

Uruk, in southern Iraq, around 3500 bce. Uruk was the first true city anywhere in the ancient Near East, and probably the largest city on Earth at the time. It was also where the region’s wedge-shaped cuneiform writing was invented,

Aug 15, 2026

Note:

For timeline of largest cities

Aug 15, 2026

1. Builders and Organizers

Page 13 | Highlight (Yellow)

By this time, humans had been living on the planet for millions of years, modern humans (*Homo sapiens sapiens*) for around 200,000 years. They had been speaking fully developed languages for at least tens of thousands of years.

Aug 15, 2026

Page 14 | Highlight (Yellow)

This period is called the Neolithic, and in the Near East it lasted from around 10000 bce to around 5300

Aug 15, 2026

Note:

Neolithic 10K-5K BC
Settlements, farming, store food

Aug 15, 2026

Page 16 | Highlight (Yellow)

At that time, perhaps as many as 40,000 of the newly urbanized people lived in Uruk. A gathering of that many people today at a football stadium would be unremarkable, and a town of 40,000 is not a big place in the modern world. But for the fourth millennium bce, it was astounding. The world had never seen anything like it. In fact, a city that big continued to be a rarity for millennia. Uruk was 2.5 square kilometers (a square mile) in extent, and was on a completely different scale from its neighbors: ten times the size, in fact, of the next biggest city in the region.⁶ Uruk was already the same size as Athens in 500 bce, 3,000 years later.⁷

Aug 15, 2026

Page 18 | Highlight (Yellow)

complex was called the Eanna, the “house of the heavens.” Within the Eanna stood a truly remarkable

Page 18 | Highlight Continued

building. We often describe things offhandedly as “unique” while knowing that it’s not really true, but this building was exactly that. Nothing remotely like it has ever been found. It was constructed during what the excavators called Level VI, around perhaps 3500

Aug 16, 2026

Note:

Heaven Temple in Uruk

Aug 16, 2026

Page 34 | Bookmark (Blue)



Fig. 3.7 Close-up of lines and symbols on the Uruk tablet, Uruk period (Joh. Börschmann/Verlag der Antiken- und Münzhandlung Berlin, 1977).

This top register of the tablet includes some details, on the right, that aren't found on other tablets: a bull and a lion and the two-headed bird, which would have reached the entrance to the sanctuary of the goddess, are some items that would have been found inside. These include two more animal heads, two tall trees (which the same shape as the Uruk tree itself), and two small animals. The strongest objects in this group, though, are two small figures standing on pedestals, which are, in fact, set on the backs of bearded men. The figure at the back is accompanied by a small bull-headed symbol, whereas the one in front has a fish-like head with a small bull-like head (a bull's head). And that's the most striking thing about these plaques of birds: they became a sign in the early years.

Aug 17, 2026

Page 41 | Highlight (Yellow)

At the beginning of Level IV at Uruk, many new monumental buildings were constructed in the sacred precinct of the Eanna in the heart of the city.¹² By now, the complex was immense; it covered about 9 hectares (22 acres).¹³ To give you a sense of scale, that is an area about three times larger than the much later acropolis in Athens.

Aug 18, 2026

Note:

Try to make Timeline w/ levels of Uruk

Aug 18, 2026

Page 44 | Highlight (Yellow)

On the earliest proto-cuneiform tablets, the administrators included numerical signs impressed with a stylus, in various shapes, with no indication of what was being counted. After a while, they began to divide up the surface of the clay tablet with incised lines, and to add pictograms to identify commodities (see Fig. 2.1). Each box on the front of the tablet—the obverse—usually contained a number and a picture.

Aug 18, 2026

Note:

3200 BCE

Aug 18, 2026

Page 49 | Highlight (Yellow)

We know from images on early cylinder seals that a favorite social event involved arranging chairs around a big pot of beer, gathering friends or family members together, and drinking it through long straws (see Fig. 2.2). Kushim might well have done this himself,

Aug 18, 2026

Page 52 | Highlight (Yellow)

It's a list of fields, and for each field, the scribe provided its dimensions—the length, the width, the perimeter or the area of the field—along with the profession of the person who controlled it. They were all important officials. At the end, of course, is a total of all the land listed. The first five fields listed were rectangular, of about the same large size, and three times as long as they were wide. Throughout Mesopotamian history, fields were generally long and narrow.⁵¹ The landscape seems to have been divided up pretty regularly, even at this remarkably early date. A centralized authority hides behind this fact;

Aug 18, 2026

Note:

3100 BC in Jemdet Nasr

Aug 18, 2026

Page 54 | Highlight (Yellow)

Although houses haven't been excavated at Uruk itself, we know from other Mesopotamian cities of the same period that their houses had rooms, furniture, doors, and windows (though without glass, which had not yet been invented). They cooked their meals in ovens and ate from pottery bowls. Their diet was based on bread, fish, vegetables (they loved onions and garlic), fruits, and some meat (beef, pork, lamb, goat). They drank beer. They wore clothes made of wool and linen.

Aug 19, 2026

Note:

Why no houses excavated in Uruk?

Page 54 | Highlight (Yellow)

I suspect that it will change a great deal more in future and that “ancient history” will come to be seen as everything up to about the beginning of the eighteenth century ce when technology began to leap forward.

Aug 19, 2026

Note:

shifting boundaries of history

Aug 19, 2026

Page 57 | Highlight (Yellow)

Inana in the Eanna temple (see Fig. 2.3). Excavators found a life-size marble face during the excavations there that is surely too carefully made to be anything but a representation of the goddess herself.⁵⁵ It now resides in the National Museum of Iraq in Baghdad: a strikingly naturalistic marble representation of a woman whose eyes, eyebrows, and hair would have been inlaid with gold and semi-precious stones (though these inlays are lost). Her body would have been made of wood or precious metals.

Aug 19, 2026

3. Kings and Subjects

Page 64 | Highlight (Yellow)

By now, the signs no longer looked anything like pictures; the script from this era onward is called “cuneiform.” In the Early Dynastic period, a few people began to use cuneiform to write about themselves—not often, and not in much depth—but we get clearer glimpses of them in the cuneiform texts.

Aug 19, 2026

Note: cuneiform 2900 bc

Aug 19, 2026

Page 68 | Highlight (Yellow)

The city of Umma was watched over by the god Shara, whose temple was one of the most impressive in all of Sumer.¹² The ruler of Umma controlled not just the city itself but several smaller cities and towns,¹³ along with the villages and lands around the city—it was a city-state. Sumer was dotted with city-states, each home to at least one city god or goddess and each with its own government. (The same was true of the region of Akkad, which lay to the north of Sumer.) Directly to the east of Umma was its neighbor, the city-state of Lagash, with which it is always associated, as though they were ancient twins (though very argumentative twins).

Aug 19, 2026

Note:

3 Mesopotamian city-states: (map them)
1) Sumer (city: Umer)
2) Akkad
3) Lagash
+ Kish in Iraq
2900-2300 BC - Early Dynastic period / Kings

Aug 19, 2026

Page 71 | Highlight (Yellow)

There is one other achievement that he thought to include, this one next to the second image of the king: he “had ships of Dilmun submit timber as tribute from foreign lands (to Lagash).”²² Dilmun was hundreds of kilometers to the south of Lagash on the shores of the Persian Gulf, in what is now Bahrain. It seems improbable that Lagash controlled Dilmun, so the “tribute” may have been something more in the nature of trade, but evidence from Bahrain confirms that it was serving as a trading center for the whole

Aug 19, 2026

Note:

King Ur-Nanshe of Lagash takes
trade from Dilmun in Bahrain

Aug 19, 2026

Page 72 | Highlight (Yellow)

Ur-Nanshe rarely mentioned war or conflict—only twice, in fact. In his longest inscription he wrote that he “went to war against the leader of Ur and the leader of Gesha” and that he “defeated and [captured] the leader of Ur” and “defeated the leader of Gesha.”²⁵ Gesha was used as another name for Umma, the city-state that neighbored Lagash. This was the start of the long hostilities between the two kingdoms. He fought farther away, as well, in Elam, to the east of Lagash in what is now western Iran.

Aug 19, 2026

Note:

Map all of these + city states on
prev note

Page 75 | Highlight (Yellow)

Obviously, the alleged reigns in the Sumerian King List were absurdly long and lay in the realm of legend, not history, but they tell us that the people of Early Dynastic Sumer probably believed themselves to be living at the endpoint of more than 400,000 years of civilization. To their minds, their culture was almost inconceivably old and well established. They would have been astonished to know that we see them as having been right at the beginning.

Aug 19, 2026

Page 83 | Bookmark (Blue)



Aug 20, 2026

Page 84 | Highlight (Yellow)

The tombs at Ur were excavated in the 1920s, and they made for sensational news at the time. They were excavated by a team led by a British archaeologist named Leonard Woolley. He employed many workmen on the site at Ur, who uncovered literally thousands of tombs during their excavations.

Aug 20, 2026

Page 87 | Highlight (Yellow)

Tombs like this have been discovered at a site called Tall Ahmad al Hattu, but from an earlier period than the tombs at Ur.60 At Tall Ahmad, as at Ur, elite people had been buried in houses for the dead.

Aug 21, 2026

Note:

How many tombs like this do
we have yet to find?

Aug 21, 2026

4. A Queen, a Reformer, and Weavers

Page 92 | Highlight (Yellow)

Lugalanda took the throne in Lagash, around 2400 bce, queen Baranamtara did not immediately take over control of the queen’s estate,

Aug 21, 2026

Page 93 | Highlight (Yellow)

The E-Mi palace was located in the city of Girsu, which was the capital of the city-state of Lagash at this time.

Aug 21, 2026

Page 95 | Highlight (Yellow)

An important alliance for Baranamtara was with the queen of the city-state of Adab, which lay just upriver of Lagash; the two states shared a border.

Aug 21, 2026

Note:

2400 BC

City State Lagash King Lugalanda

Aug 21, 2026

Page 96 | Highlight (Yellow)

To put this in perspective, Dilmun was about 850 kilometers (530 miles) from Lagash, and Urenki would have traveled most of that way, if not the whole way, by boat. Seaworthy boats had been built long before cities developed, though their captains probably stayed within view of the coast as they traveled. It would have been a difficult journey, but evidently was worth the risk. Copper was needed everywhere for making bronze. The copper was not mined in Dilmun, though. It had come from even farther away, from what is now Oman (ancient Magan), where archaeologists have found evidence for extensive mining and smelting.²⁵ Dilmun

Aug 21, 2026

Note:

Could draw out some sea trade routes

Aug 21, 2026

Page 104 | Highlight (Yellow)

to have overthrown his predecessor in a violent way.⁴⁸ Urukagina (mid-twenty-fourth century bce) wanted life in Lagash to go back to the way it had been in the past, or at least to the way he imagined it had been, in some earlier, less decadent time. This would be a way of life that would restore (as he saw it) an appropriate respect for the state god Ningirsu, who would no doubt approve of his actions. Urukagina claimed, using the third person about himself, that “he (re)established the norms of old; the commands which his king the divine Ningirsu had commanded him.”⁴⁹ Many people, he believed, had been getting rich at the expense of the state and the temples; those people were to be removed from their positions, and even his own royal court was to become a religious institution. “He put the house of the ruler (and) the fields of the ruler in (the hands of) the divine Ningirsu his king.”⁵⁰

Aug 21, 2026

Note:

LOL MABA

Aug 21, 2026

5. Royal Couples, Divine Couples, and Envoys

Page 112 | Highlight (Yellow)

The cuneiform tablets found at the site of Ebla didn't give up their stories easily.¹ In 1974, when Italian excavators first discovered the main archive room in the ancient palace,² the sight of the clay tablets must have been almost overwhelming. As the archaeologists carefully removed the dirt, thousands of cuneiform tablets appeared, piled on the ground, some still in exactly the order in which they had been placed 4,300 years ago, before the palace burned down

Aug 22, 2026

Note:

How was this site found? Potential
for more like it?

Aug 22, 2026

Page 114 | Highlight (Yellow)

King Ishar-damu of Ebla around 2300 bce, the kingdom was flourishing. Ishar-damu ruled from a sprawling and finely built palace in the capital city, a little more than 54 kilometers (33 miles) south of the already important city of Halab (now Aleppo).⁸ The palace, which archaeologists uncovered, was spread out over 2,400 square meters (almost 26,000 square feet)⁹ on an acropolis overlooking the city. The city wall would have been visible in the distance, surrounding the 60 hectares (148 acres) of densely packed buildings that made up Ebla.

Aug 22, 2026

Page 115 | Highlight (Yellow)

During Ishar-damu's reign, Ebla was one of the major kingdoms of his era; it included at least twenty cities that recognized him as their king, it was home to more than 700 villages that were mentioned in the archives,¹⁰ and it stretched at least 200 kilometers (125 miles) from east to west across northwest Syria. The kingdom of Ebla bordered other powerful kingdoms of the day, Nagar to the east in the Habur River region, and Mari to the southeast along the Euphrates.

Aug 22, 2026

Page 126 | Highlight (Yellow)

The former kings were gods now, deified after death. The names of these earlier kings of Ebla, sadly, mean nothing to us. We have just a list of them, carefully recorded, passed down by scribes over generations, and found in the excavation of the palace.⁶² There are twenty-six names on the list, but documents only survive from the reigns of the last four to rule before the destruction of the kingdom—Kun-damu, Igrish-Halab, Irkab-damu, and Ishar-damu—and the vast majority of the tablets that were found in the excavations at Ebla date to just the last two of those.⁶³ Those other kings on the list—they're just names without stories. Some of

Page 126 | Highlight Continued

them would no doubt have been as familiar to the people of Ebla as George Washington or Abraham Lincoln are to Americans today.

Aug 23, 2026

Page 134 | Highlight (Yellow)

Two men, Enar-Lim and Ruzi-malik, made some of the longest journeys from Ebla, traveling all the way to a distant place called Dugurasu.

Aug 24, 2026

Page 136 | Highlight (Yellow)

One has the sense that the journey back and forth between Ebla and Egypt would have been a familiar one to these men who were traveling together. The first leg of the journey from Ebla took them to the Mediterranean coast at Kakmium. From there, they traveled south, either on foot or by boat, with a stop at the coastal city of Dulu, which was almost certainly an ancient name for Byblos. Archaeology shows that Byblos already had a long history of trade with both Egypt and Syria, and the tablets show that Dulu was one of Ebla's most reliable trading partners, providing many of the same goods that came from Dugurasu. The expedition then continued on from Dulu to Egypt—Dugurasu. They would have traveled about 1,370 kilometers (850 miles) to get there, a journey that would have taken them about two months. With a stay when they got there and the return journey to follow, Enar-Lim and Ruzi-malik were leaving Syria for at least six months. One can't help wondering what the merchants thought of the lands they visited, and all the varying landscapes and cities they encountered along the way. The roads in the kingdom of Ebla and beyond it were well traveled. The people of Ebla knew that a wide world extended beyond their immediate domain, and the mechanisms of diplomacy were well established. Formal gift exchange with distant kings may, in fact, have been more reliable than trade in providing luxury goods for the court.

Aug 25, 2026

Note: map this

Aug 26, 2026

6. A Conqueror and a Priestess

Page 145 | Highlight (Yellow)

Sargon (c. 2316–2277 bce) is the earliest Big Name in Mesopotamian history. Few people today have heard of Ur-Nanshe, Enmetena, or Ishar-damu, let alone Baranamtara or Tabur-damu. But Sargon is familiar. He is even sometimes known as "Sargon the Great"—the world's first empire builder, the first man to unite Mesopotamia from the Persian Gulf to the Mediterranean.

Aug 26, 2026

Page 146 | Highlight (Yellow)

Sargon's name and achievements were therefore familiar to people in the region for about 2,000 years, and we hear about him a lot from their later writings. Curiously, though, if the only clues we had were documents

Page 146 | Highlight Continued

and objects that were created in Sargon's own time, he might seem inconsequential—just one of hundreds of kings whose reigns came and went without leaving much trace.

Aug 26, 2026

Note:

2000 years later just like Jesus

Aug 26, 2026

Page 147 | Highlight (Yellow)

Before Sargon began his imperialistic campaigns, Lugalzagesi, king of Umma (c. 2320 bce), was busily uniting (and laying waste to) much of southern Mesopotamia. The city-state of Umma was, as we have seen, the perpetual nemesis of the city-state of Lagash. They had battled for so long over their shared border that inhabitants of both city-states must have viewed the feud as some kind of fact of life. Soldiers from each state must have assumed that they would forever be sent out by their king with spears, bows, and arrows to fight for their god—Ningirsu (for Lagash) or Shara (for Umma)—to reclaim control of the lands of the Gu'edena. But King Lugalzagesi brought an end to the feud, conquering both Umma's rival, Lagash, and the ancient city of Uruk, to which he then moved his capital. By Lugalzagesi's time, approximately 1,200 years had passed since Uruk had emerged as the first great city of Mesopotamia.

Aug 27, 2026

Page 151 | Highlight (Yellow)

Unfortunately, there is no way to know if any of this was true because Agade has not yet been found. Archaeologists do know where to look, though—Sargon's new capital probably was built somewhere near the confluence of the Tigris and Adhaim Rivers, north of what is now Baghdad.

Aug 29, 2026

Note:

How can this not be found?

Aug 29, 2026

Page 151 | Highlight (Yellow)

A giant fragment of an over-lifesize statue of a man made of basalt was found there at a site called Qadasiyah—it would have been a statue appropriate for a capital city (see Fig. 6.2). When complete, the figure stood about 2.75 meters (9 feet) tall, bigger than anything else known from this era.³⁸ Was this Sargon? It might have been. All that is left are his bare feet,

Aug 29, 2026

Note:

So we ~may~ have the feet of
Sargon @ what may be Agave

Aug 29, 2026

Page 153 | Highlight (Yellow)

But Sargon was not content with the traditional trading mechanisms; he initiated a new era of trade by inviting foreign traders and their boats directly to his capital. He boasted in one inscription that boats from Magan, Dilmun, and Meluhha docked at the harbor in Agade.

Aug 29, 2026

Note:

consider post: where is Agade?
Elephants passed through LOL

Aug 29, 2026

Page 154 | Highlight (Yellow)

Sargon decided to name the years; at the end of each year, he chose one of his recent great achievements to be the name of the year that was beginning. Scribes were supposed to use this year-name whenever a date was needed on a document. It was Sargon's cunning way of reminding his people of his power, and it created a precedent. Mesopotamian kings regularly used year-names as a form of propaganda for more than 700 years after his reign and, in a few states, kings even continued to name their years for at least three more centuries after that.

Aug 29, 2026

Page 154 | Highlight (Yellow)

Remember that his throne name was already propagandistic, so anyone mentioning the name of a year couldn't help repeating two ideas that Sargon wanted to reinforce—his legitimacy and his military might. Hence, a farmer might say, "I first grew barley in this field during the year when 'The king is legitimate' destroyed Elam."

Aug 29, 2026

Page 165 | Highlight (Yellow)

the most obvious reason for the collapse was that a people called the Gutians invaded Akkad from the Zagros

Page 165 | Highlight Continued

mountains to the east.

Aug 31, 2026

7. Brickmakers, Litigants, and Slaves

Page 167 | Highlight (Yellow)

After the Gutians had conquered Agade and helped bring an end to the Akkadian Empire, no one could claim to be king of the whole land. Even the author of the Sumerian King List, who normally valiantly maintained the fiction of a united Mesopotamia, despaired of making any sense of this era. "Who was king? Who was not king?" he wrote.¹ This period was mystifying to the ancient writer and remains so to us.

Sep 1, 2026

Note:

1) Timing

2) Any hope of discovering author of Sumerian King List?

Sep 1, 2026

Page 175 | Highlight (Yellow)

One day, as one of these bricks was drying in the sun, a dog walked across it, leaving clear paw prints in the clay (see Fig. 7.4). Was this a feral dog wandering through the brickmaking yard? No one knows. Dogs had been domesticated in the Near East thousands of years earlier, perhaps as early as 13,000 bce,²³ and they would have been a familiar sight in the city.

Sep 3, 2026

Note: bricks for ziggurat at ur

Sep 3, 2026

Page 176 | Highlight (Yellow)

A scholar has calculated that the first level alone of the ziggurat at Ur would have required the manufacture of a staggering 7,595,100 baked and sun-dried bricks.²⁵ Our brickmaker would have spent months, perhaps years, doing nothing during his days but mixing clay, molding bricks for this building, and stacking them on their sides to harden.

Sep 3, 2026

Page 179 | Highlight (Yellow)

Ur-Namma's laws predate Hammurabi's by more than 300 years. Ur-Namma promulgated his laws at the height of his reign, after he had, as he noted in an inscription, "liberated Akshak, Mirad, Girkal, Kazallu, whatever (territories) were under the subjugation of Anshan."³⁸ This was one of his few references to military action. The cities listed were to the north of Ur, in the region of Akkad, whereas Anshan was about 800 kilometers (about 500 miles) to the south and east of Ur, near modern Shiraz in Iran.

Sep 4, 2026

Page 191 | Highlight (Yellow)

King Ur-Namma's death came suddenly. According to a line in a literary account that may have been commissioned by his widow Watartum, he might have died in battle, but he might also have died naturally.

Sep 5, 2026

Note:

LOL this means nothing

Sep 5, 2026

Page 193 | Highlight (Yellow)

The whole project of administering this system depended on an army of scribes keeping records of every sheep, goat, ox, and bushel of grain that came into and went out of the royal warehouses. Much of the processing of goods took place at a specially constructed redistribution center that Shulgi founded near

Nippur. It was called Puzrish-Dagan and was the origin of many of the Ur III records. Shulgi's administrative reforms affect us now, as we look at the sweep of ancient Near Eastern history, because the scribes who ran this system created a veritable flood of cuneiform records (see Fig. 7.6). About 100,000 tablets written in the Ur III period have been found so far, and hundreds of thousands more must remain in the ground. It's estimated that about 500,000 cuneiform documents are housed in museums and private collections around the world from all eras of ancient history,¹¹² so about a fifth of them were written during the Third Dynasty of Ur, most of those from Shulgi's reign and those of his successors. They represent just a few decades out of the more than 3,000 years that cuneiform was in use.

Sep 5, 2026

Note:

Map in H3tan'0

Sep 5, 2026

8. Sparring Kings and Their Military Commanders

Ur ————— Ki'sura — border 646 Isin + Larsa
Nippur —————→ N

Sep 5, 2026

Page 202 | Highlight (Yellow)

Ishbi-Erra and the kings who were his descendants are known as the First Dynasty of Isin; they dominated much of Sumer during the 1900s bce. They did their best to make it seem as though the Ur dynasty had not ended. In fact, they continued to call themselves “Kings of Ur” for seventy years.

Sep 5, 2026

Page 203 | Note

After Ur: Isin vs Larsa (2000 BC)

Sep 5, 2026

Page 204 | Highlight (Yellow)

And so, in the early 1920s bce, we see kings of Isin being replaced by King Gungunum of Larsa, who took over Kisurra and who imposed his year-names. But, late in the decade, by 1921 bce, the city was back in the kingdom of Isin, with that king's year-names replacing those of the king of Larsa. For a brief time Kisurra claimed independence—four kings of a local dynasty controlled the land (and the year-names),¹⁵ but then the king of Larsa was back again in 1910 bce. Twelve more years passed and the city was again in Isin's kingdom. Nine more years and it was in Larsa again. And so it went, on and on for decades, in dizzying succession, until 1802 bce.

Sep 5, 2026

Page 211 | Highlight (Yellow)

Quite a lot more is known about Sumu-El, beyond his letters from the battlefield. He had come to power in 1894 bce, as the seventh king of Larsa. It had been thirty-two years since his predecessor King Gungunum had taken control of Ur and ended the era in which Isin could claim to be home to the “kings of Ur.” Larsa, rather than Isin, now saw itself as Ur's rightful heir.

Sep 5, 2026

Page 212 | Highlight (Yellow)

and to undermine the power of Isin. As we have seen, Sumu-El was proud of his military victories and keen to let everyone know about them in his year-names and inscriptions. Curiously, though, none of the details from his letters were mentioned in his year-names for the period

Sep 5, 2026

Note:

On this year's board, we should list
all known year-names

Sep 5, 2026
